

For more than one reason: you need to practise the way you'll speak on stage (as opposed to how you speak to your dog). You'll need to see how long you'll spend on each slide—using the slide timing feature—so you can cut down on time in some places and increase time in others. Your rehearsal can also be a good time to re-look your slides, with their fonts and themes. You need to rehearse so you know what to point at with your laser pointer if you're using one. There are more reasons to rehearse, but we'll end with the idea that it is, after all, a stage performance we're talking about.

Tip

Our collective informed guess tells us 78% of presentations aren't properly rehearsed. 82% of presenters think PowerPoint is God, and that once they've put up their slides, things will go smoothly. Get out of that mind-set. Rehearse. Speak. Convey.

2.3 The Eight-fold Path

Purists will say this section is beyond the scope of this book; pragmatists will agree that no encyclopaedia, tome, book, journal, flyer, or leaflet on PowerPoint is complete without a section on how to deliver a presentation. For as we shall explain in the first tenet of this eight-fold path to delivering wisdom, PowerPoint is only a tool; it's less than half the story. In fact, we're picking up now from "it's a stage performance we're talking about."

Here's the other half—or more than half—of the story: what to do on stage while your slides are on, and how to do it.

2.3.1 Talk

This is tenet #1 for sure. The audience has come to hear you, not to look at images on a screen. Had the latter been the case, they could have done it in their cubicles or at home. Yes, your slides must be compelling, but your speech should be equally compelling, if not more so.